

WHY I DO ALL THIS WALKING, OR HOW SYSTEMS BECOME FRAGILE

Relearn to walk—Temperance, he knew not—Will I catch Bob Rubin? Extremistan and Air France travel

ANOTHER FEW BARBELLS

Again, thanks to the exposure the book has received, I was alerted to a new aspect of robustness in complex systems ... by the most unlikely of sources. The idea came from two fitness authors and practitioners who integrated the notions of randomness and Extremistan (though of the Gray Swan variety) into our understanding of human diet and exercise. Curiously, the first person, Art De Vany, is the same one who studied Extremistan in the movies (in [Chapter 3](#)). The second, Doug McGuff, is a physician. And both can talk about fitness, particularly Art, who, at seventy-two, looks like what a Greek god would like to look like at forty-two. Both were referring to the ideas of *The Black Swan* in their works and connecting to it; and I had no clue.

I then discovered to my great shame the following. I had spent my life thinking about randomness; I had written three books on dealing with randomness (one technical); I was prancing about as the expert in the subject of randomness from mathematics to psychology. And I had missed something central: living organisms (whether the human body or the economy) *need* variability and randomness. What's more, they need the Extremistan type of variability, certain extreme stressors. Otherwise they become fragile. That, I completely missed.*

Organisms need, to use the metaphor of Marcus Aurelius, to turn obstacles into fuel—just as fire does.

Brainwashed by the cultural environment and by my education, I was under the illusion that steady exercise and steady nutrition were a good thing for one's health. I did not realize that I was falling into evil rationalistic arguments, the Platonic projection of wishes into the world. Worse, I had been brainwashed though I had all the facts in my head.

From predator-prey models (the so-called Lotka-Volterra type of population dynamics), I knew that populations will experience